

Hey, friends. It is Eric Malzone. And in this short audio lecture, we are going to talk about the editing process.

First and foremost, full disclosure, I've done very little editing myself. I'll just lay that out there right now. That being said, I know a lot of successful podcasters, people who have been in this game for a long time, and they really enjoy the editing process. To them, it's really critical. It's how they stay connected to the podcast, and they really enjoy it.

For me, there are a lot of processes that I will do that many others won't. Things like acquiring guests, preparing guests, writing the email newsletters, doing the social media. A lot of people will delegate those, or outsource those. It's really just comes down to your time, your resources, what interests you and where you think you get your biggest bang for your buck.

So that's just mine. And my editor helped me pull together this outline, so it is quite intensive. So let's just get into it now. Why is editing so important?

Well, professionalism and quality, number one. Editing really transforms your raw recordings into a polished, professional episode that captivates and retains the listeners. Maybe that initial recording that was clunky, or full of pauses, or background noises, or things that you feel didn't go well, the editing process can really mold it into something quite special. And you'll be surprised with what good editing can do to an episode.

So next is consistency and clarity. So it ensures your content is clear, concise, and consistent-- the three C's. Just made that up. Enhancing the overall listening experience.

Engagement-- so well-edited podcasts are simply more engaging. They keep your audience coming back for more.

On the flip side, a poor audio experience is a very, very hard thing to overcome. I don't care how great the actual content is, the topics, the guests, whatever it may be, we've all probably experienced it. You get really excited about an episode. You go to listen, and it's just unbearable how bad the audio quality is. So editing is absolutely critical, and you should pay a lot of attention to it up front.

And last thing I'll say about this. It's OK if you need a lot of editing when you're getting started. It's 100% normal. As you get more reps and become increasingly more fluid, you'll need less and less editing.

And I also think that little imperfections in the editing process can actually bolster relatability and engagement with your audience. So sometimes the little ums, and the ahs, or maybe a little bit of background noise or something just makes people feel like they're sitting in the room with you. And that's really important.

And as I just did, it happens all the time. And it's not something to worry too much about. So don't try to be perfect, is what I'm trying to say.

OK, so let's get into the pre-editing preparation. So number one, organize your files. So before you start editing, make sure that all your files are well organized, named appropriately, put in the right place.

Personally, my editor and I have been using a very, very simple process. It includes Google Drive, WhatsApp, and then my recording software of choice, which is right now riverside.fm. So that changed over the years quite a few times. That's what I like right now as of the date of this recording. But really do your research on that.

And it goes as simple as this is. Once I'm done recording, I put the appropriate files, both video, and audio, into Google Drive. Into a folder specifically with the name of that specific episode, what I want to name it, who the guest is. Any specific editing instructions, things like headshots, bios, all of that goes into one neat little folder. And then a bunch of magic happens, a.k.a. My editor, and it gets published.

So we're going to go through what that magic is specifically, but it can be as simple as a Google Drive. And then we use WhatsApp to communicate because she's overseas. So really simple stuff.

Choosing the right software. Nowadays, the recording software does a lot of this. It has a lot of these things built-in.

So something to look into is make sure you're not paying for two things within a recording software and an editing software. If a lot of the stuff overlaps and you have everything you need in your recording software. So just a word of caution as you do that. But the more traditional options for editing are Adobe Audition, Audacity, GarageBand and Hindenburg Journalist.

Setting up your workspace. So always strive to create a distraction-free environment that simply allows you to focus and be productive. Like anything else, maintaining focus makes the process go smoothly and very efficiently. I will say that headphones are an excellent idea, if that's not obvious. It really locks you into the sound quality.

The editing workflow. OK, so first and foremost, you're going to import your audio files. So start by importing your recorded audio files into your chosen editing software.

Pretty simple. It depends on, of course, if you're doing it remotely, you're going to have a recording software. If you're doing in person, you may have a hard drive that you need to pull it off of. But that's step one.

Initial cleanup. So just remove any of the obvious mistakes-- long pauses, background noises, dogs barking, doors slamming, sirens going off. All that stuff is going to happen, and you have the opportunity to remove that. And there's some really great tools now, like Noise Reduction Equalization that do it automatically for you. So very smart stuff.

Note on this-- today's tools are excellent, and they're only getting better and less expensive as artificial intelligence changes the landscape of podcast publishing. So just be aware of all the tools out there. Do a little bit of research.

Structuring your episode. So in a most traditional sense, you're going to want to arrange the audio clips in the desired sequence-- so introduction, main content, transitions, outro. You can do fine tuning with tools like cutting, trimming, crossfades. All this stuff ensured smooth transitions between segments.

And then you want to add the elements-- things like incorporating music, sound effects, sponsor message-- just make sure they enhance rather than distract from the main content. And sponsoring messages, there's a lot of science into where you want to place those and how you want to read them. The best way to do it is just organically bring it up within the actual interview or within the podcast episode.

Sometimes it's just not that easy, so you want to have something pre-recorded and where you want to put it. Either in the beginning of the episode, in the middle of the episode, or the end of the episode. The end of the episode tends to be the least engaging, so I wouldn't recommend that. But play around with it.

Equalization and compression-- so you can adjust the EQ-- otherwise known as equalizing-- settings to balance the frequencies, and use compression to maintain consistent audio levels.

Quality control and finalization-- so first and foremost is just listen through the entire podcast before you publish it. I know it's a little bit more time intensive, but it's well worth it. Because you will catch things you didn't catch the first time around, and you can adjust those quite easily.

Feedback-- so I would always recommend, especially as you're getting started, maybe send over the draft to some trusted friend, a colleague, a family member. Get their honest feedback, and see if there's any adjustments that you need to make there, as well.

Exporting-- so export your final episode in the appropriate format. Usually that is MP3 for most podcast hosting platforms. But double check on that and see what the format is. But like I said, usually MP3.

Tips for efficiency-- so this is something I got from my editor. She's a master at keyboard shortcuts. So depending on what computer you have or software you're using, learning and using keyboard shortcuts really speed up the process. So it takes a minute to learn upfront, but definitely worth it.

Batch processing-- when you're doing repetitive tasks like this, it's really nice to set a chunk of time on your calendar where you can do multiple episodes at once than doing one at a time sporadically throughout the week or month. It really helps efficiency. And you can get it done much faster, especially if you're really locked in to the workflow.

Staying organized-- like we talked about here-- systems, systems, systems. Keep your editing projects and files organized to streamline the workflow. I find that publishing calendars or project management softwares like Trello can be super valuable through the editing and publishing process. So be as organized as you can. But also don't overcomplicate it by having too many softwares, because those costs start to rack up pretty quick.

Now, if you're like me, you probably went through this and you're like, ooh, man. I think I'd rather just hire someone to do that. Well, the good news is that it's becoming quite cost efficient to hire an editor, and a very high quality one.

When it comes time to pick the right editor, it's a big deal. So referrals are always the best. So ask someone within your immediate network, or someone in a podcast community that you may know if they have any referrals. They probably do.

People can be a little funny about referring their editors, because they don't want their podcast to lose priority. But that's just human nature, right? Generally the good ones get recommended around quite a bit.

But I would ask people who, if you listen to their podcast, you're like, darn, that's really good. Find out who their editor is, if they use one. It's really important to get great quality, great communication, consistency and value.

I think that sounds obvious, but it's kind of like if you ever hired a house cleaner. Sometimes they can come in and they'll do the first one or two jobs really, really well. And then they tend to maybe slack off a little bit, take it for granted as you go.

So just make sure that when you find someone who's really consistent and has great communication that you hold on to them. And things like time zone, language, their workload, their professionalism, if it's a personality fit. This is a people business, so do you actually enjoy working with the person? That's really important, too.

So before you actually hire them full-time, I would say try to test out an episode or maybe a series of five or so. See how they work. And then when you find the right one, you feel really good about it, lock them in and get them into a retainer versus a per episode. That's just my personal preference.

So thank you for listening. This is the editing process. It can be quite fun.

I would encourage you to do it, personally, before you hire someone-- at least for a few episodes. I did that in the beginning, just so I understood it. So if something happened, I could keep the machine going.

But it is a cool process. It is very magical. And I hope you enjoy it. This is Eric Malzahn. Thanks for listening.